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St. Louis Cardinals 2026 End of Season Tender/Non-tender Decision Analysis
Roster as of 10/15/26

The purpose of this analysis is to evaluate the St. Louis Cardinals' tender and non-tender decisions following the 2026 MLB season. I built a dated player universe and collected publicly available contract, service-time, arbitration, and option information from FanGraphs Roster Resource. The publicly available service-time information was available through the 2025 season, so I used MLB Stats API roster and transaction records to reconcile each player's 2026 MLB service and combine it with pre-2026 totals. This allowed me to estimate service time through the end of 2026 and classify players as pre-arbitration, potential Super Two candidates, or arbitration-eligible players. I then combined 2026 FanGraphs performance data with Baseball Savant and Statcast information, compared actual performance with preseason 2026 ZiPS and ZiPS DC projections, and used 2027 ZiPS projections as a public starting point for evaluating future value. FanGraphs describes ZiPS DC as ZiPS prorated to Depth Charts playing time. The 2027 ZiPS figures come from FanGraphs' 2026 preseason multi-year projections and therefore do not incorporate players' subsequent 2026 performance. Where complete contract information was unavailable, I used Just Baseball's public arbitration salary estimates as working estimates for arbitration-eligible players. Those figures are estimates, not verified arbitration awards.

The ZiPS and ZiPS DC projections are used as public quantitative baselines, not as definitive forecasts. I compare them with actual performance, roster context, contract cost, internal alternatives, and my own evaluation of each player. Models provide an objective starting point, while scouting, coaching, medical, player-development, and roster context help determine how much confidence to place in those forecasts. My goal is to approximate that process using public data and clearly identified judgment.

This analysis is limited by the lack of the proprietary information and financial infrastructure available to a professional baseball operations department. It does not include a complete organizational payroll and budget model, league-wide replacement-value model, internal player projections, medical evaluations, injury-risk assessments, biomechanics or athletic-training data, or player development and organizational context. The public projections, salary estimates, defensive metrics, and service-time classifications also contain uncertainty. In particular, some contract information is incomplete, the 2027 Super Two cutoff is not yet final, and the 2027 CBA may change the applicable rules.

A more complete evaluation would include historical MLB and minor-league performance, multiple projection systems, player-specific playing-time and role forecasts, pitch-level and batted-ball data, swing decisions, biomechanics, athletic-training and injury information, medical

evaluations, and player-development assessments. It would also require a financial model that compares projected on-field value with expected salary, arbitration outcomes, free-agent and trade-market alternatives, internal replacement value, 40-man roster opportunity cost, Rule 5 protection needs, and the value of preserving future roster flexibility. I would like to continue learning how to test these recommendations using more advanced data across multiple health, performance, playing-time, and roster scenarios.

I organized the recommendations into straightforward tenders, tenders with important caveats, decisions requiring detailed valuation, and non-tender or alternative cases.

Easy tender decisions: clear retention cases

1. Michael McGreevy — Tender. Pre-arbitration and arguably the Cardinals' best controllable starting pitcher. He produced approximately 1.88 WAR in 2026, and 2027 ZiPS projects approximately 2.11 WAR.

2. Quinn Mathews — Tender. A top pitching prospect with major-league experience in 2026, three options remaining, and 2027 ZiPS projection of approximately 1.13 WAR. His limited service time and development value make this a clear tender.

3. Brycen Mautz — Tender. A top prospect with major-league experience in 2026, two options remaining, and a 2027 ZiPS projection of approximately 0.99 WAR. His 2026 major-league sample was small, but his prospect status and controllability make this a clear tender.

4. Gordon Graceffo — Tender. Pre-arbitration and inexpensive, with value as bullpen or pitching depth. He produced approximately 0.57 WAR in 2026, and 2027 ZiPS projects approximately 0.98 WAR. His one remaining option creates some roster flexibility.

5. Hancel Rincon — Tender. Pre-arbitration with three options remaining and essentially no major-league service time. His 2027 ZiPS projection is modest but positive, and his controllability makes retaining him preferable to exposing him to waivers.

6. Luis Gastelum — Tender. Pre-arbitration with three options remaining and limited service time. He provides inexpensive pitching depth and has a positive 2027 ZiPS projection.

7. Cooper Hjerpe — Tender. Based primarily on prospect status, controllability, and two remaining options. His major-league sample is very small, and the repository does not

currently contain a 2027 ZiPS projection for him, so this recommendation is based more on organizational control and development value than on a complete projection.

8. Leo Bernal — Tender. Based on prospect status, controllability, and catching value. He produced approximately 0.81 WAR in a limited 2026 sample, while 2027 ZiPS projects approximately 2.11 WAR.

9. Jimmy Crooks — Tender. Based on prospect status, controllability, catching depth, and two remaining options. His 2026 major-league production was limited, but 2027 ZiPS projects approximately 2.05 WAR.

10. Joshua Báez — Tender. A controllable pre-arbitration prospect with two options remaining. His 2026 sample was limited, while 2027 ZiPS projects approximately 1.56 WAR. His development value makes this a straightforward tender.

11. Nathan Church — Tender. Pre-arbitration with three options remaining and substantial playing time in 2026. He received 470 plate appearances, produced approximately 0.40 WAR, and is projected for approximately 0.95 WAR in 2027.

12. Masyn Winn — Tender. A straightforward arbitration tender based on his established shortstop role and expected defensive value. He produced approximately 2.30 WAR in 2026, while 2027 ZiPS projects approximately 3.32 WAR. Just Baseball estimates his 2027 salary at $4.0 million, though I would value him slightly below that figure because of injury history and concerns about declining defensive metrics.

13. Iván Herrera — Tender. An arbitration-eligible catcher with no MiLB options remaining, but with established offensive value and approximately 1.39 WAR in 2026. ZiPS projects approximately 1.60 WAR in 2027. Just Baseball estimates his 2027 salary at $2.9 million.

14. Alec Burleson — Tender. Entering his second arbitration year after producing 3.20 WAR, 125 wRC+, 26 home runs, and 116 RBI in 670 plate appearances in 2026. His 2027 ZiPS projection declines to approximately 1.26 WAR, but his established role and offensive production support a tender. His 2026 salary was $3.3 million. Just Baseball projects a $3.6 million raise, bringing his total salary to $6.9 million, though I could see the final figure moving higher depending on comparable arbitration cases and the organization's willingness to retain him.

Tender decisions with important caveats

15. Tekoah Roby — Tender. Top prospect with no recorded major-league service time and a positive 2027 ZiPS projection of approximately 1.37 WAR. His opening assignment is less certain because he has one option remaining, is returning from Tommy John surgery, and has never pitched in the majors. The tender decision is easy; the service-time and roster strategy is not.

16. Richard Fitts — Tender. Controllable and 2027 ZiPS projects approximately 0.98 WAR. Like Roby, he is returning from Tommy John surgery and has only one option remaining. His opening-day assignment will depend on his recovery timeline and the balance between service time and roster strategy.

17. Max Rajcic — Tender. He is pre-arbitration, has three options remaining, and retains development value after Tommy John surgery in 2026. I project that he will be optioned to the minors and begin the season on the minor-league 60-day injured list as he rehabs from TJ, using one of his options without accruing service time.

18. Ryan Fernandez — Tender. He provides inexpensive pitching depth, has one option remaining, and produced approximately 0.21 WAR in 2026. ZiPS projects approximately 0.38 WAR in 2027. His potential Super Two status in 2028 creates some future cost, but not enough to outweigh his current controllability and depth value.

19. Matt Svanson — Tender. This is one of the less certain decisions in the group. His 2026 results were poor, including a 7.27 ERA, although his 2027 ZiPS projection improves to approximately 0.43 WAR. His command issues and one remaining option create meaningful roster risk.

20. Cade Winquest — Tender. He is pre-arbitration, has two options remaining, and remains a controllable pitching option after his Rule 5 selection and DFA by the Yankees. However, 2027 ZiPS projects only approximately 0.23 WAR with a 5.28 ERA, so he is a potential non-tender or roster-space casualty if the organization’s internal evaluation is unfavorable.

21. Hunter Dobbins — Tender. He is controllable and produced approximately 0.44 WAR in 2026. Although 2027 ZiPS projects approximately 0.88 WAR, that total is highly unlikely given the timing of his Tommy John surgery at the end of 2026. The tender decision is based on his expected value beyond 2027: his usage this year supports projecting him as an MLB starter. I project that he will use his final MiLB option and begin 2027 on the minor-league 60-day injured list as he recovers, with the goal of joining the MLB starting rotation in 2028.

22. Chase Hampton — Tender. Subject to 40-man roster constraints. He is a controllable pre-arbitration pitcher with two options remaining, but the Cardinals acquired him late in 2026 and have had limited time to evaluate him internally. He could become a roster-space casualty if the Cardinals need to protect Rule 5-eligible prospects.

23. Thomas Saggese — Tender because he remains controllable and 2027 ZiPS projects approximately 1.32 WAR. However, he has only one option remaining. The downside is that keeping him in the minors could create a future roster problem if he is not ready for a major-league role before the organization must make another decision on him.

24. Bryan Torres — Tender because he is pre-arbitration with two options remaining and has a positive 2027 ZiPS projection of approximately 1.07 WAR. The main uncertainty is roster fit rather than cost or control.

25. Jordan Walker — Tender, because of his age, established a major-league role after his 2026 production, and long-term upside. He produced approximately 2.71 WAR in 2026, but 2027 ZiPS projects -0.31 WAR, creating a substantial disagreement between actual performance and the forward projection. This remains a tender, but the projection conflict should be acknowledged. Just Baseball estimates a 2027 salary of $3.55 million. His 2026 production may lead him to seek more, but in my opinion, his previous performance limits his arbitration upside from the team perspective.

26. Victor Scott II — Tender. He is a controllable, relatively inexpensive outfield-depth option. I project that he can spend most of 2027 in the upper minors, use his final option, and be recalled for the postseason if needed. His defensive range and baserunning value could make him useful as a late-season or postseason defensive replacement. His 2026 offensive performance was poor, but 2027 ZiPS projects approximately 1.95 WAR. He remains valuable as a controllable depth player.

27. José Fermín — Tender. He is a valuable, controllable versatility piece, especially if Nolan Gorman is non-tendered. His 2027 ZiPS projection is approximately 1.09 WAR, and his value depends partly on the Cardinals' need for a player who can cover multiple positions.

28. Blaze Jordan — Tender because he is pre-arbitration, has three options remaining, and has limited service time. However, the 2027 ZiPS projection is slightly below replacement level at approximately -0.15 WAR. His prospect status and low cost support retention, but this is one of the weaker cases within the controllable-player group.

Detailed tender valuations required

Tender-leaning cases

29. Andre Pallante — Tender. His 2026 durability, mid-rotation production, and ability to provide starter or swingman innings fill a meaningful roster need. His low strikeout rate, regression indicators, and projected decline in workload and WAR create legitimate performance risk, but the Cardinals lack an obvious internal replacement for his reliability. I would value him at roughly $6 million rather than the public $7.5 million estimate, reflecting both his projected contribution and the uncertainty in his underlying indicators.

30. Matthew Liberatore — Tender, but with less confidence than Pallante and at a disciplined valuation. His 155 innings and left-handed starter profile have real roster value, while the 2027 ZiPS projection suggests a rebound to 1.84 WAR despite a projected workload decline. His below-average stuff indicators, high home-run rate, and projected salary near $4.1 million make him a clear risk, especially with left-handed pitching prospects in the pipeline. Retain him for 2027 as a bridge and evaluation year, then make him a likely non-tender candidate after the season if his stuff and run prevention do not improve.

31. Kyle Leahy — Tender. 140 innings, 2.56 WAR, and ability to cover both rotation and bullpen roles justify taking a shot despite the 2027 ZiPS projection assuming only 82 innings. His below-average stuff creates performance risk, but his above-average location and strong 2026 workload suggest that the projection may understate his practical role value. The recommendation is stronger if he falls short of Super Two, but I would still tender him at Just Baseball's estimated $1.95 million arbitration salary. Reassess his role and underlying stuff after 2027.

32. Justin Bruihl — Tender, but salary-sensitive if he qualifies as a Super Two. His 77.2 innings, left-handed relief profile, and above-average Stuff+, Location+, and Pitching+ support retaining him despite a modest 2027 projection that ranks 31st of 36 Cardinals pitchers. His 4.39 SIERA compared with a 3.59 ERA creates regression risk, and the absence of a verified salary estimate makes the arbitration cost the key unknown. If he misses Super Two, I would tender him confidently; if he qualifies, tender him only if the expected award remains reasonable for his projected role.

33. Riley O'Brien — Tender, but somewhat salary-sensitive if he qualifies as a Super Two. His 2026 closer workload, 0.31 WAR, above-average stuff, and closer experience support retaining him despite a 2027 ZiPS projection that ranks 32nd of 36 Cardinals pitchers. His below-average location and 4.08 BB/9 create risk, while the lack of a public 2027 arbitration estimate makes cost the key unknown. If he misses Super Two, I would tender

him confidently; if he qualifies, keep him only if the award remains reasonable for his projected bullpen role.

34. Everson Pereira — Tender, but make him roster-conditional rather than a clear tender. His 147 wRC+ in 23 plate appearances and projected 17-homer power give him enough upside to justify a stash, but the sample is tiny and the 31.3% projected strikeout rate, negative defensive projection, and zero remaining options increase roster risk. He is pre-arbitration, so salary is not the main issue; the key decision is whether the Cardinals can afford his 40-man spot over a Rule 5 player or another outfielder. Keep him if roster space allows and the club believes he can convert more of his raw power into sustainable offense, but he is a legitimate non-tender candidate if the roster tightens.

Non-tender, trade, or alternative cases

35. George Soriano — Non-tender. His 66 innings, -0.28 WAR, 4.77 BB/9, and below-average Location+ and Pitching+ do not show enough underlying value to justify carrying him. His 2026 performance was broadly projection-consistent, and the 2027 ZiPS projection is only 0.14 WAR, ranking 26th of 36 pitchers. Even if he avoids Super Two and would be cheaper, the Cardinals' right-handed depth and stronger internal alternatives make the roster spot more valuable elsewhere.

36. Nolan Gorman — Non-tender. His 2026 line (.184/.272/.308, 62 wRC+, -0.55 WAR) and 32.5% strikeout rate made him a below-replacement player. His 2027 ZiPS projection calls for a rebound to 2.20 WAR, a 106 wRC+, and 22 home runs, but that upside is far from certain. At Just Baseball's estimated $3.155 million Arbitration Year 2 salary, the redundancy among the Cardinals' left-handed hitters and the roster opportunity cost make the rebound risk too high.

37. Pedro Pagés — Non-tender. Defense-first catcher who appeared in 84 games in 2026 and produced roughly 0.56 WAR, about one-third of his 2026 ZiPS projection and one-half of his 2027 projection, without offering a notable offensive surplus. Although his projected salary of approximately $1 million is manageable, he ranks behind Leo Bernal and Jimmy Crooks in the Cardinals' projected 2027 catching value, with Raniel Rodriguez and Ryan Campos providing additional organizational depth. Assuming Iván Herrera is strictly a DH, I would retain Pagés only if Bernal or Crooks is traded. Otherwise, I would explore trading Pagés before the tender deadline. If no trade materializes, I would non-tender him and allocate the 40-man roster spot elsewhere.

38. César Prieto — Non-tender. Pre-arbitration with one minor-league option remaining, making him a controllable and relatively inexpensive asset, but his 2026 production was

poor: .079/.103 with a 2.6% walk rate and 12.8% strikeout rate in only 39 plate appearances. The small sample limits the certainty of any offensive conclusion, and although his public fielding and defensive metrics were positive, his roughly -0.44 WAR was well below his 2026 ZiPS projection of 1.15 WAR while his 2027 projection is only 0.47 WAR. He ranks 21st among the 41 hitters in the project's Cardinals comparison, so I would use the 40-man roster spot elsewhere unless the organization has stronger internal evidence that his defense and offensive development give him a clear major-league role.

Outside the standard tender analysis

- Ryne Stanek — Club option for 2027 rather than a standard tender/non-tender decision.
- JJ Wetherholt — Guaranteed money for 2027 and beyond, so he is not part of the standard tender/non-tender analysis.

Rule 5:

The current notable potential Rule 5 protection list includes:

1. Jesús Báez
2. Colton Ledbetter
3. Pete Hanson
4. Chenwei Lin
5. Jacob Odle
6. Chase Davis
7. Won-Bin Cho

If the Cardinals decide to protect players from this group, they will need to create corresponding 40-man roster spots. Some roster removals may need to occur before the tender deadline to create space for Rule 5 protections. The most likely players to be revisited because of this constraint are Chase Hampton, Cade Winquest, Matt Svanson, Everson Pereira, Pedro Pagés, and César Prieto.